agency that is crushing him. While sometimes taken as an existential or theological reference to the human condition in the universe and to the unfathomability of God, on a more mundane level the story highlights the potentially nightmarish character of bureaucracies, which as an insurance lawyer Kafka knew all too well.

In bureaucratic societies, the lives of ordinary people are often upended by unidentified officials of an unfathomable agency for incomprehensible reasons. Whereas stories about heroes who confront monsters – from the *Ramayana* to Spider-Man – repackage the biological dramas of confronting predators and romantic rivals, the unique horror of Kafkaesque stories comes from the unfathomability of the threat. Evolution has primed our minds to understand death by a tiger. Our mind finds it much more difficult to understand death by a document.

Some portrayals of bureaucracy are satirical. Joseph Heller's iconic 1961 novel, *Catch-22*, used satire to illustrate the central role bureaucracy plays in war. One of the most powerful figures in the novel is ex-private first class Wintergreen, who from his power base in the mail room decides which letters to forward and which to disappear.[45] The 1980s British sitcoms *Yes Minister* and *Yes, Prime Minister* showed the ways that civil servants use arcane regulations, obscure subcommittees and piles of documents to manipulate their political bosses. The 2015 comedy-drama *The Big Short* explored the bureaucratic roots of the 2007–8 financial crisis. The movie's arch-villains are not humans but collateralised debt obligations (CDOs), which are financial devices invented by investment bankers and understood by nobody else in the world. These bureaucratic Godzillas slumbered unnoticed in the depths of bank portfolios, until they suddenly emerged in 2007 to wreak havoc on the lives of billions of people by instigating a major financial crisis.

Artworks like these have had some success in shaping perceptions of how bureaucratic power works, but this is an uphill battle, because since the Stone Age our minds have been primed to focus on biological dramas rather than bureaucratic ones. Most Hollywood and Bollywood blockbusters are not about CDOs. Rather, even in the twenty-first century, most blockbusters are essentially Stone Age stories about the hero who fights the monster to win the girl. Similarly, when depicting the dynamics of political power, TV series like *Game of Thrones*, *The Crown* and *Succession* focus on the family